



TECHNICIAN FIELD GUIDE

Mole Biology • Property Assessment • Trapping • Customer
Communication

Serving Pierce, King & Snohomish Counties
Veteran-Owned & Operated

CONFIDENTIAL — FOR GOT MOLES TECHNICIANS ONLY

Version 1.1 — 2026 (Updated)



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Section 1: Know Your Target — Mole Biology & Behavior

Understanding moles is the foundation of everything we do at Got Moles. The more you know about how they live, move, eat, and build, the faster and more accurately you will trap them. This section covers the three species in Pierce, King, and Snohomish Counties, how to tell them apart, and the biology that directly affects your trapping.

1.1 The Townsend's Mole (*Scapanus townsendii*)

The Townsend's mole is the largest mole species in North America and the one you will encounter most frequently on residential properties in our service area. This species is the primary driver of the damage our customers call about.

Physical Characteristics

- **Size:** 8-9 inches total, 4-5 oz (130-150g). Dense, compact — heavier than it looks.
- **Fur:** Velvety dark gray/black. No natural grain — lays flat in any direction for bidirectional tunnel movement.
- **Front paws:** Massively oversized, paddle-shaped, turned outward. Extraordinary digging leverage.
- **Eyes:** Tiny, concealed, nonfunctional for sight. Detect light/dark only. Navigate by touch, vibration, smell.
- **Snout:** Hairless, pink, covered in Eimer's organs — microscopic sensors detecting prey movement and vibrations.
- **Tail:** Short, thick, mostly hairless. Sensory function when moving backward.

Habitat & Range

Pacific coast from SW British Columbia to NW California. In Washington, concentrated in lowlands west of the Cascades — our service territory. Prefers open areas with moist, well-drained soils rich in organic matter: lawns, golf courses, parks, irrigated fields. Key factor is moisture and earthworm density.

Tunnel Architecture

Complex multi-level system. Permanent deep tunnels run 6–20 inches below the surface as main highways, used repeatedly day after day. Shallow feeding tunnels run 1–4 inches below — the raised ridges across lawns. Many shallow tunnels are used once. Deep tunnels can reach 10+ feet when passing under roads or foundations.

Volcano-shaped mounds form when moles push excavated soil straight up from deep tunnels. A single mole can produce remarkable numbers of mounds quickly.

FIELD NOTE

Townsend's moles can tunnel up to 18 feet per hour. One mole creates damage that looks like multiple animals. When a customer says "I must have a dozen," it's usually 1–2.

1.2 The Pacific Coast Mole (*Scapanus orarius*)

The coast mole is the second species in our area. Smaller than the Townsend's with broader habitat tolerance and some distinct behavioral differences.

Physical Characteristics

- **Size:** 6–7 inches, 2–3 oz (60–80g). Noticeably lighter. Tail proportionally longer (~1/4 of body length).
- **Fur:** Uniformly dark gray/black, velvety. Nearly identical to Townsend's in appearance.

- **Skull:** Relatively narrow and long — useful ID feature when comparing specimens.

Habitat & Range

Broader tolerance than the Townsend's. Occupies drier, brushier, and wooded habitats in addition to open lawns. Found in nearly every habitat except wet, swampy ground. In our area, more common near wooded properties, drier/sandier soils, and less irrigated yards.

Behavioral Differences

Smaller, less dramatic mounds. Shallower, less extensive tunnel systems. Eats roughly twice body weight in earthworms daily. Can operate in tighter, more compacted soils. Has been documented foraging on the surface in wet leaf litter at night — uncommon for the Townsend's.

★ **NEW SECTION — Added Version 1.1**

1.3 The Shrew Mole (*Neurotrichus gibbsii*)

The shrew mole is the smallest mole in North America and the third species you may encounter in our service area — though far less common on residential lawns. It is easily confused with voles and is the hardest of the three species to trap.

Physical Characteristics

- **Size:** 3-4 inches total — roughly half the size of the Coast mole.
- **Fur:** Dark brownish-black, velvety. Much smaller profile than other moles.
- **Forepaws:** Smaller than both other species — produces noticeably smaller, less dramatic molehills.
- **Tail:** Relatively long for a mole, partially scaled and hairy.
- **Eyes:** Tiny but slightly more developed than the Townsend's.

Habitat & Range

Shady ravines, stream banks, moist second-growth forests, and wooded edges. Rarely found in the center of open, irrigated residential lawns. If a customer's property borders woodland, ravines, or has heavy tree cover, this species is more likely.

Key Behavioral Differences

- Unlike other moles, the shrew mole is frequently active ABOVE GROUND — especially at night and in wet leaf litter.
- Tunnel systems are shallower and less extensive than Townsend's or Coast moles.
- Molehills are small and flat — easy to mistake for vole activity.
- Social: occasionally travels in small groups, unlike the solitary Townsend's.
- Eats earthworms, insects, and plant material — broader diet than other moles.

FIELD NOTE

Often confused with voles — hardest species to catch. If activity is near wooded edges with small, flat disturbances, probe carefully. Standard Victor sets still work; adjust to shallower placement. If in doubt, consult supervisor.

1.4 Field Identification

Being able to tell the species apart demonstrates professionalism and helps adjust your approach.

Feature	What to Look For
Size (most reliable)	Townsend's: over 8", chunky. Coast: under 7", lighter. Shrew: under 4". If it feels like a hefty potato = Townsend's.

Feature	What to Look For
Mound size	Townsend's: large, 6-12" tall. Coast: smaller, flatter. Shrew: very small and flat.
Tunnel depth	Townsend's: extensive deep systems. Coast: tends shallower. Shrew: shallowest.
Habitat context	Irrigated lawn = likely Townsend's. Near trees/drier = may be Coast. Wooded edges/ravines = may be Shrew.
Above-ground activity	Townsend's: never. Coast: occasional at night. Shrew: frequent, day and night.

CUSTOMER TALKING POINT

“We primarily deal with the Townsend’s mole here — the largest mole species in North America. One animal can create all the damage you’re seeing across your whole yard.”

1.5 Mole Diet & Feeding Behavior

Primary: Earthworms

55-93% of diet. Townsend’s eats 60-80% of body weight daily. Coast mole eats up to twice body weight — roughly 100-150 individual worms per day. They patrol permanent tunnels continuously and dig new feeding tunnels to explore fresh ground.

Secondary

Grubs, beetle larvae, centipedes, millipedes, slugs, snails. Townsend’s is the only western species that also eats underground plant material.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Moles do NOT eat grass roots, bulbs, or vegetables as primary food.

That damage is voles/gophers using mole tunnels. Tell customers:

“The moles are after worms and grubs, not your plants.

The damage is from tunneling.”

1.6 Tunnel Systems

Deep Runs (Permanent) — YOUR PRIMARY TRAP TARGET

Main highways 6-20 inches deep, used repeatedly for months/years. Travel between feeding areas, nest, and territory. Follow straight or gently curving paths along physical barriers: foundations, fences, walkways, driveways, garden borders. Highest-percentage trap locations.

Volcano-shaped mounds indicate deep tunnels but are just dump sites — never set a trap in a mound.

Surface Runs (Feeding)

Raised ridges 1-4 inches deep. Many used once and abandoned. Runs along edges or connecting to deep systems may be productive. Confirm activity visually and with probing.

Nest Chambers

Typically under trees, shrubs, or buildings in well-drained areas. Heavy mound clusters may indicate a nest. Females line nests with moss, grass, and leaves during breeding.

TRAP PLACEMENT RULE

Always prioritize deep runs over surface runs.

Edge runs (foundations, fences, walks) = highest probability.

Never set in a mound. Always 18+ inches away.

1.7 Activity Patterns & Seasonal Behavior

Year-Round

Moles do NOT hibernate. Active 365 days/year in western Washington.

Daily

4–5 hour active cycles day and night. Peak surface activity early morning and late evening, increasing after rain or irrigation.

Seasonal

- **Spring (Mar–May):** High surface activity. Juveniles disperse. Excellent trapping.
- **Summer/Peak (Jun–Oct):** Soil dries, moles go deeper. Trap placement must be more precise. Target deep runs near irrigated areas, foundations, shade.
- **Fall (Oct–Nov):** Rains return, surface activity increases. Good trapping window.
- **Winter (Dec–Feb):** Deeper tunnels, still active. Breeding begins. Concentrated in deep runs.

DRY SEASON (JUNE–OCTOBER)

Soil dries = more precise trap setting required.

Earthworms go deeper, moles follow.

Target irrigated zones, shade, foundation edges.

1.8 Breeding & Dispersal

- **Mating:** December–March. Males extend tunnels seeking females.
- **Gestation:** 4–6 weeks.
- **Litter:** Townsend’s avg 3 (1–4). Coast 2–4, increasing with age.
- **Birth:** March–April. Born naked, blind, with large forelimbs.

- **Dispersal:** Pups leave nest at 30–36 days (May–June). Establish own territories via new tunnels or above-ground travel. #1 cause of new activity on cleared properties.
- **Lifespan:** ~3 breeding seasons (3–4 years).

WHY TMCP MATTERS

Juvenile dispersal is why Quick Fix customers see moles return.

“We’ve cleared your current moles, but young moles disperse every spring. TMCP catches them before they get established.”

1.9 Mole vs. Vole vs. Gopher

Feature	Mole	Vole	Gopher
Type	Insectivore (NOT rodent)	Small rodent	Rodent
Size	6–9”	4–6”	6–12”
Paws	Large, paddle-shaped	Small, normal	Large, clawed
Diet	Worms, grubs, insects	Plants, grass, roots	Roots, tubers
Mounds	Round/volcano, no plug	None; surface paths	Crescent w/ plug

Section 2: Property Assessment & Routing

A thorough, methodical assessment separates a professional from someone who sticks traps in the ground and hopes. This is the Got Moles standard.

2.1 Customer Contact Protocol

1. Park neatly. Truck clean and organized — it represents Got Moles.
2. Knock on door. Greet customer by name if known.
3. First visits: “Hi, I’m [Name] with Got Moles. I’m here to take care of your mole situation.”
4. Ask: “What’s been going on? Show me the areas that bother you most.” Let them talk.
5. Build rapport. Be personable, interested. Foundation of trust and TMCP.
6. No answer? Proceed to assessment. Leave door hanger or jobber note.

CRITICAL MINDSET

Every visit builds the relationship.

Quick Fix customers = future TMCP. TMCP customers = referrals.

Treat every property like your most important account.

2.2 The Property Walkthrough

Before you touch a trap, walk the entire property. Non-negotiable.

1. Walk entire perimeter. Note foundations, fences, walkways, driveways, patio edges.

2. Walk interior systematically. Note every mound, ridge, disturbance.
3. Mental map: Where do tunnels connect? Where do mounds cluster? Run direction?
4. Identify deep runs: straight connections between mounds, edge runs, intersections.
5. Check for concentrated mound clusters — possible nest area.
6. Note soil type and moisture. Plan technique adjustments.
7. Mental note of trap inventory needed. Gather equipment.

2.3 Reading the Yard

Fresh vs. Old

- **Fresh mounds:** Loose, damp soil matching subsurface color. Recent activity.
- **Old mounds:** Dried, crusted, grass growing through. Where moles were.
- **Fresh ridges:** Soft, springy turf. Grass may be yellowing.
- **Old ridges:** Settled, compacted, regrown. Lower priority.

Key Patterns

- **Edge runs:** Foundations, fences, sidewalks. Mole highways = highest priority.
- **Connecting runs:** Straight lines between mound clusters = deep runs.
- **Under-obstacle runs:** Activity both sides of walkway/driveway = tunnel underneath.
- **Meandering runs:** Aimless wandering ridges = exploratory, lowest priority.

2.4 Active vs. Inactive Tunnels

Visual Assessment & Probe Method

Setting traps in inactive tunnels wastes time. We use visual assessment and probing:

- Fresh mounds with loose, damp soil — clearest indicator of current activity.
- Recently raised surface ridges with soft turf.
- Runs along edges — almost always active main highways.
- Straight connections between mound clusters — high-probability deep runs.
- Activity on both sides of hardscape = deep tunnel underneath.

Using Your Probe Rod

Your most important assessment tool. Locate deep runs between mounds and along edges. When the rod drops into a void, you've found a tunnel. Probe multiple spots to trace direction and depth before committing a trap.

2.5 Choosing Trap Locations

Priority Ranking (Highest to Lowest)

- 1.** Deep runs along foundations, fences, hardscape edges.
- 2.** Deep runs connecting mound clusters in a straight line.
- 3.** Deep runs under walkways/driveways (set on either side).
- 4.** Tunnel intersection points.
- 5.** Active surface runs along edges or connecting to deep runs.
- 6.** Active surface runs in open lawn (lowest priority).

Always set traps at least 18 inches from any mound.

2.6 Soil Type Assessment

Soil Type	Technique
Clay	Most straightforward. Solid dam, deep legs, clear run. Highest catch rates.
Loam	Good conditions. Standard technique.
Sandy (wet)	Manageable. Pack dam slightly firmer.
Sandy (dry)	Most difficult. Add grass/vegetation to dam. Pack extra firmly.
Amended soil	Very loose. Compact firmly, add organic material.

2.7 Jobber Documentation

Return to truck and document immediately after setting traps.

- **Traps:** Number, type, specific locations.
- **Activity:** Light/moderate/heavy. Where freshest.
- **Soil:** Type, moisture, technique notes.
- **Customer:** Concerns, pets/kids, focus areas.
- **Inventory:** Track what's deployed.

Section 3: Trap Selection & Placement

All the biology knowledge and assessment skill means nothing if you can't set a trap correctly. This section covers setup, placement, and the standards that separate professional from amateur.

3.1 Our Trap Inventory

1. Victor Scissor Traps

Our workhorse. Below-ground scissor-jaw trap set inside the tunnel. Effective in deep and surface runs. Note: Newer Victors have quality issues. Inspect every trap — springs tight, jaws close cleanly. We are developing our own proprietary replacement.

2. Trapline Mole Traps

Purpose-built for direct tunnel placement. Scissor mechanism with sensitive trigger. Excellent in clay/loam. Must be bedded (pressed into soil floor) for maximum effectiveness.

3.2 Victor Scissor Traps: Setup

- 1.** Locate the deep run with your probe rod. Note the depth.
- 2.** Using a small spade shovel, cut a neat plug of sod and soil just wide enough for the trap. Precision cut — the plug goes back in cleanly. Think of it as cutting a lid.
- 3.** Lift plug carefully and set aside.
- 4.** Clear the tunnel opening. Confirm the trigger bar (dog) has room to swing freely.
- 5.** Build a soil dam in the center. Moist soil packed firmly, completely blocking the tunnel.

6. Safety catch on. Wedge trap firmly, jaws straddling tunnel. Trigger pan snug against dam.
7. Center trigger plate at mid-height of the tunnel.
8. Replace the sod plug to block light and restore the lawn surface. Neat and tidy from above.
9. Release safety catch. Place wire flag.

3.3 Trapline Mole Traps: Setup

1. Locate tunnel with probe rod.
2. Cut a neat plug with small spade shovel. Same standard — clean, replaceable.
3. Clear debris. Both sides need clean paths. Confirm trigger bar has room.
4. Set trap per manufacturer instructions.
5. Place deep — nothing above tunnel ceiling.
6. Bed the trap: press into soil floor. Critical — un-bedded traps rock and moles avoid.
7. Replace plug. Stake with wire flag.

DIGGING STANDARDS

We are professionals on people's lawns. Every hole: neat, tidy, easy to replace.

Small spade shovel. Just wide enough for the trap.

Plug goes back in, lawn looks close to how you found it.

We are NOT hacking up the yard.

3.4 The Perfect Set

THE PERFECT SET CHECKLIST

- ✓ Maximum trigger surface touching the dam
- ✓ Room behind trigger to fire
- ✓ No debris between jaws
- ✓ Clean entry on BOTH sides
- ✓ Trigger centered at mid-height
- ✓ Trap bedded firmly — no rocking
- ✓ Light blocked
- ✓ Wire flag placed

3.5 The Rule of Four

Four traps is the magic number for standard residential properties.

- **Standard:** 4 traps in the 4 highest-priority locations.
- **Larger:** 4–6. Only for distinct, separated activity zones.
- **Commercial:** Variable. Discuss with supervisor.

NEW TECH MISTAKE

More traps ≠ more catches. 4 well-placed traps in deep runs outperform 10 scattered across surface tunnels. Quality > quantity.

3.6 Soil-Specific Techniques

Clay

Best friend. Solid dam, deep legs, clear run. Holds shape. Highest catch rates.

Sandy (Wet)

Manageable. Slightly firmer dam.

Sandy (Dry)

Most challenging. Add grass/vegetation to dam. Pack extra firmly. Check more frequently.

3.7 Trap Checks & Follow-Up

Service Type	Schedule
Quick Fix	Weekly visits for duration of service. Move/reset as needed.
TMCP (new activity)	Return to weekly immediately.
TMCP (maintenance)	Weekly → Biweekly → Monthly. Step up for new activity.

At Each Check

1. Locate traps by flags.
2. Fired? Recover mole, reset or relocate.
3. Not fired? Mole go around? New activity? Soil collapsed? Adjust.
4. Walk property for new mounds/ridges.
5. Update Jobber notes.

IF NOT FIRED AFTER 2 CHECKS

Move it. Tunnel may be inactive, set may be off, or mole changed routes.
Don't keep checking a dead set.

3.8 Common Mistakes

Mistake	The Fix
Inactive tunnels	Confirm activity. Fresh soil, edge runs, probe rod.
Not deep enough	Fully seated at travel depth. Probe to confirm.
Trigger not tight	Max surface touching dam. Loose = mole pushes through.
Debris in jaws	Clean both surfaces before setting.
Traps in mounds	Mounds are dump piles. 18+ inches away.
Too many traps	4 well-placed > 10 scattered.
Rushing walkthrough	10 min saved costs catches all month.
Sloppy digging	Clean plug, small spade, easy to replace. Not hacking.
Light in tunnel	Replace sod plug, cover every opening.
Not bedding (Trapline)	Press into soil floor. Un-bedded = mole avoids.

Section 4: Customer Communication & the Got Moles Experience

You are the face of Got Moles. How you communicate affects retention, TMCP enrollment, referrals, and reputation. Every interaction builds trust.

4.1 First Impressions

- **Be on time.** If late, communicate proactively.
- **Look professional.** Clean shirt, truck, organized equipment.
- **Eye contact.** Smile. Confident introduction.
- **Ask questions.** Let them tell you the problem. Genuine interest.
- **Empathy.** “I can see this has been frustrating — we’re going to take care of it.”

★ **UPDATED SECTION — Aligned with Training Program V3**

4.2 Service Process Framework: A, B & C

Got Moles uses three named service processes that map to every visit you’ll make. Know which process you’re running before you step out of the truck.

PROCESS A — Initial Set (New Customer)

- Full property walkthrough — non-negotiable, every time.
- Introduce yourself and gather information from the customer.
- Educate on mole biology and what we’ll do.
- Set 4 traps in the 4 highest-priority locations to Perfect Set standard.

- Build rapport and lay the foundation for TMCP conversation.
- Jobber documentation. Departure protocol.
- Allow 30–45 min for this visit.

PROCESS B — Repeat Visit (TMCP Maintenance / 5–7 Min)

- Locate all traps by flags.
- Check each: fired = recover mole and reset; not fired = evaluate and adjust.
- Walk property for new mounds or ridges.
- Move traps that haven't fired after 2 consecutive visits.
- Update Jobber notes. Leave property clean.
- No re-selling. These are your established accounts — efficient and professional.

PROCESS C — Service Completion & Upsell

- Property is clear. Confirm with customer walkthrough.
- Deliver the TMCP bridge conversation (see script below).
- Explain juvenile dispersal and why moles return.
- Offer TMCP at \$100/month — everything included.
- Document outcome in Jobber.

4.3 Straight Line Framework: Visit 1

Run the Straight Line from your first visit. Professional process, not high-pressure sales.

The Four Pillars

- 1.** Gather information. What they see, how long, what they've tried, biggest concerns.
- 2.** Build rapport. Comment on property, find common ground. Human, not robot.
- 3.** Expand pain point. Reflect frustration + expert context: "What you're dealing with is a Townsend's — biggest in

North America. They don't stop."

4. Build trust through expertise. Walk property with them, point things out, explain. Position as authority.

4.4 Explaining What We Do

- "Moles are insectivores, not rodents. After the earthworms and grubs."
- "Townsend's is the largest mole in North America — right here."
- "One mole tunnels 18 feet per hour. Looks like a dozen, usually 1-2."
- "Active all year — no hibernation."
- "Ridges are shallow feeding tunnels. Below those: permanent highways."
- "We target the deep tunnels for highest success."

4.5 Words That Work & Avoid

Use These	Never Say
"Mole activity" / "infestation"	"Easy" — Sets unrealistic expectations
"We're going to take care of this"	Timeline promises
"Based on what I'm seeing..."	"I think" / "Maybe" — Speak with confidence
"The Total Mole Control Program"	"Subscription" / "monthly plan"

4.6 TMCP vs. Quick Fix

Quick Fix (\$450)

Weekly visits for duration of service. Full experience: assessment, communication, education, follow-up. Every Quick Fix is an audition for TMCP. Run Process A on the initial set, Process B for each follow-up visit.

TMCP (\$100/month)

Established accounts. Run Process B on every visit: evaluate, move/add traps, document, move on. Friendly and professional, no re-selling. These are the backbone of the business. When a property clears, run Process C to complete and convert.

4.7 Building Toward TMCP

TMCP BRIDGE SCRIPT

"We'll get after the moles here now. The thing to know is moles breed in spring and young ones disperse into new territories.

Your neighbors' moles become yours. The Total Mole Control Program gives year-round monitoring — \$100/month, everything included."

4.8 Departure Protocol

- 1.** Return to truck.
- 2.** Enter all Jobber notes immediately.
- 3.** If customer's outside: "Traps are set. I'll be back [day]. Call if you see anything."
- 4.** Leave property clean. No tools, trash, or soil.

Section 5: Quick Reference Cards

5.1 Property Visit Checklist

PROPERTY VISIT CHECKLIST

- ☐ Truck neat and organized
- ☐ Knock, greet, ask, listen, build rapport
- ☐ Walk ENTIRE perimeter before touching a trap
- ☐ Walk interior — all mounds, ridges, edges
- ☐ Identify deep runs: edges, connections, under-obstacle
- ☐ Assess soil type and moisture
- ☐ Select 4 highest-priority trap locations
- ☐ Set to Perfect Set standard
- ☐ Flag all locations, replace sod plugs
- ☐ Jobber notes, goodbye, leave clean
- ☐ Know your process: A (initial), B (repeat), C (completion)

5.2 Trap Placement Checklist

TRAP PLACEMENT CHECKLIST

- ☐ Tunnel confirmed active
- ☐ Deep run or high-priority surface run
- ☐ At least 18" from any mound
- ☐ Clean plug cut with small spade
- ☐ Dam solid and packed
- ☐ Max trigger surface touching dam
- ☐ Room behind trigger to fire
- ☐ Jaws clean
- ☐ Clean entry both sides
- ☐ Trigger bar (dog) can swing freely
- ☐ Trigger centered at mid-height
- ☐ Trap bedded firmly
- ☐ Sod plug replaced, light blocked
- ☐ Flag placed

5.3 Species Comparison

	Townsend's	Pacific Coast	Shrew Mole ★
Scientific	<i>S. townsendii</i>	<i>S. orarius</i>	<i>N. gibbsii</i>
Size	8–9", 4–5 oz	6–7", 2–3 oz	3–4", <1 oz
Habitat	Open lowlands, irrigated	Varied: woods, brush, dry	Wooded ravines, stream banks
Mounds	Large, volcano	Smaller, flatter	Very small, flat
Depth	Deep (6–20+')	Generally shallower	Shallowest
Above ground?	Never	Occasional (night)	Frequent (day & night)
Breeding	Dec–Mar, avg 3 pups	Jan–Mar, 2–4 pups	Feb–Apr, 1–4 pups
Field ID	>8", heavy, short tail	<7", light, longer tail	<4", tiny, above-ground

Got Moles? — Veteran-Owned & Operated

Pierce, King & Snohomish Counties

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★ Highlighted sections indicate new or updated content from
Version 1.0

Field Notes

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